with nuclear warheads, the Soviets had on the island tactical nuclear weapons that the Americans knew nothing about. There were six Luna (US designation “Frog”) missile launchers with nine missiles and nuclear warheads. These were short-range missiles that could not reach Florida but could have been used against an American invasion force with devastating consequences. Each nuclear warhead had an explosive power of 6 to 12 kilotons of TNT, only slightly less than the 15-kiloton nuclear bomb dropped on Hiroshima in August 1945. On top of that, as McNamara learned, at one stage of the crisis it was up to the Soviet commander in the field to decide whether to use the Luna missiles or not.[1]

“We didn’t believe there were nuclear warheads in Cuba,” commented McNamara a few days later. “There was no evidence of nuclear warheads.” Arthur M. Schlesinger Jr., a former special assistant to President Kennedy and McNamara’s fellow participant at the conference, was equally taken aback. He recalled that Gribkov’s revelations had startled and appalled the Americans. “Incredible,” wrote Schlesinger, remembering his own reaction to the news. “I had earlier believed that we had overestimated the dangers of the crisis—that Khrushchev, well aware of US overall nuclear superiority as well as of US conventional superiority in the Caribbean, would never have risked war. But Soviet forces, we are now told, were ready to fire tactical nuclear missiles at an invading force.”[2]

A few hours earlier McNamara told the conference that the actions of the three main actors in the Cuban missile crisis “had been distorted by misinformation, miscalculation, and misperceptions.” But even he had not realized the depth of those misunderstandings and misperceptions. “That was horrifying. It meant that had a U.S. invasion been carried out, if the missiles had not been pulled out, there was a 99 percent probability that nuclear war would have been initiated,” McNamara told a reporter.[3]